

Shefali Shah in *Human*

LAST YEAR, AFTER SHEFALI SHAH wrapped up a film shoot, the crew brought her a cake to cut. It was shaped like a question mark. The idea came from Suresh Triveni, director of the upcoming film, *Jalsa*, also starring Vidya Balan. "He was like 'You are *KBC* [*Kaun Banega Crorepati*], man. You just don't stop asking questions'," says Shah. The actress's filmography boasts of many highlights—there's *Satya* (1998), *Monsoon Wedding* (2001), *Dil Dhadakne Do* (2015) and *Once Again* (2018), there's the short film *Juice* (2017) and, most recently, there was the critically acclaimed Netflix series, *Delhi Crime* (2019-). Shah is proud of her reputation as someone who chews her "director's brain over every line, every moment". "Either you convince me or I convince you," she says.

In *Human*, a medical drama that recently released on Disney+ Hotstar, the director on the receiving end of her incessant probing happens to be her husband—Vipul Amrutlal Shah. The two have collaborated before (*Waqt: The Race Against Time* in 2005 and *Commando 2* in 2017), but *Human* was a show specifically created with Shah in mind as the protagonist. "Vipul respects me too much to come to me with anything that's not worth my while and I also respect him too much to ever ask him to make something for me," says Shah.

Vipul is also very familiar with his wife's work process. Shah recalls that when she walked in with her note-laden copy of the script and a diary, her husband and co-director Mozez Singh quipped that they would have to delay the shoot "because this [discussion] will never get over". They also joked that they would be left with five episodes instead of the planned 10—Shah is known to cut down her lines. "Actors have this need to show how good they are in every scene. I feel like '*Kya zaroorat hai* [What's the need?]'," she says. "If you are true to your character and just react, it will all fall in place."

Meticulous as she might be, Shah often starts work on a humble note—"*Mujhe kuchh nahin aata hai* (I know nothing)—it is a great place to begin because only then can you learn and grow," she says. In *Human*, which looks at the dark underbelly of drug trials conducted by pharmaceutical companies, Shah plays Dr Gauri Nath, a neurosurgeon who wants to bring about a revolution in medicine and help ailing people. However, when such good intentions clash with ambition, all hell breaks loose.

"I was shocked and scared when I read the script," says Shah. "I have seen a documentary or two on the subject, but I didn't know the magnitude of politics and power play that goes behind it. It really is too complicated a web." Shah had no reference to play Gauri Nath, but she describes her as a "lioness", one she chose to play as a "deer". The actress modulated her voice to make her "more demure, fragile and vulnerable". It's this process to deviate from the safe, expected route which delights Shah.

Yet another addition to a growing slate of women-led narrative entertainment, *Human* again confirms that 40-something women are the reigning stars of streaming, much like 50-something actors are at the box office. From Sushmita Sen in *Aarya* (2020-) and Raveena Tandon in *Aranyak* (2021-) to Geetanjali Kulkarni in *Gullak* (2019-) and Pooja Bhatt in *Bombay Begums* (2021-), OTT platforms are together telling authentic stories about women from varied socio-economic-cultural backgrounds. This movement, though, started with the International Emmy award-winning Netflix series *Delhi Crime*, a dramatic retelling of the investigation of the Nirbhaya rape case in which Shah played the key officer, DCP Vartika Chaturvedi. The success of *Delhi Crime* only encouraged more creators to conjure worlds where women's needs and feelings are put at the forefront.

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